

Standard Format for Importing Questions

Respondus will import multiple choice, true-false, paragraph, short answer, matching and multiple response questions. The plain text, rich-text, or MS Word file must be formatted correctly before it can be imported into Respondus.

Required Elements (Multiple Choice)

Each question must begin with a question number, followed by either a full stop or parentheses.

Example: 3)

Example: 3.

The question wording must follow the question number. (At least one space should be between the question number and the question wording.)

Example: 3) Who determined the exact speed of light?

Example: 3. Who determined the exact speed of light?

Each answer choice must begin with a letter (A-Z) followed by a full stop or parentheses.

Example: 3) Who determined the exact speed of light?

- a. Albert Einstein
- b. Albert Michelson
- c. Thomas Edison
- d. Guglielmo Marconi

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Optional Elements (Multiple Choice)

A title can be imported with each question. If a title is not provided for a question, the first 20 characters from the question wording will be used as the question title. Titles must be placed at the beginning of a question and begin with Title: followed by the actual text for the title. If the title exceeds 20 characters, the remaining characters will be dropped during the import.

Example: Title: Speed of Light

3) Who determined the exact speed of light?

- a. Albert Einstein
- b. Albert Michelson
- c. Thomas Edison
- d. Guglielmo Marconi

For questions being imported to a quiz file, correct answers should be indicated with an asterisk (*) directly in front of the answer choice (do not put a space between the asterisk and the answer choice).

Example: Title: Speed of Light

3) Who determined the exact speed of light?

- a. Albert Einstein
- *b) Albert Michelson
- c) Thomas Edison
- d. Guglielmo Marconi

With a quiz file, feedback for individual answer choices can be imported by placing the feedback immediately after the answer choice and by beginning the line with the @ symbol. There must be at least one space between the @ symbol and the feedback text.

Example: Title: Speed of Light

3) Who determined the exact speed of light?

- a. Albert Einstein
- @ No. Albert Michelson determined the exact speed of light.
- *b) Albert Michelson
- @ Yes. Albert Michelson won the Nobel Prize for Physics for determining the exact speed of light.

General Feedback can be imported in a similar way, but it must appear immediately after the question wording and before any of the answer choices. The line must also begin with the @ symbol and there must be at least one space between the @ symbol and the feedback text.

Example: Title: Speed of Light

3) Who determined the exact speed of light?

@ Albert Michelson was the first American to win the Nobel Prize in Physics (1907) for his measurements of the speed of light. His experiments laid the groundwork for Einstein's Theory of Relativity.

- a. Albert Einstein
- @ No. Albert Michelson determined the exact speed of light.
- *b) Albert Michelson
- @ Yes. Albert Michelson won the Nobel Prize for Physics for determining the exact speed of light.

As shown in the previous example, both types of feedback can be used within a single question.

Importing True and False Questions

The process of importing a true and false question is similar to that used for importing multiple choice questions.

Example: 3) Albert Michelson determined the exact speed of light?

- *a) True
- b) False

Example: 3) Albert Michelson determined the exact speed of light?

- *a. T

b. F

It's important to note that the True (or T) answer choice must be listed above the False (or F) answer choice in order for Respondus to recognize it as a true and false question type. (If False appears first in the list, the question will be imported as a multiple choice question.)

To include a title or feedback with the true and false question, follow the same formatting rules described above for multiple choice questions.

Importing Paragraph Questions

The logic for importing paragraph questions is similar to what is described above for multiple choice questions. The main difference is that the first line of formatting must begin with Type: P. This is followed by the Title (which is optional), the question number, and the question wording.

Example: Type: P

Title: Michelson-Morely experiment

4. How is the Michelson-Morley experiment related to Albert Einstein's theory of relativity?

If you are importing a paragraph question into a quiz file, you can supply an answer in the following format.

Example: Type: P

Title: Michelson-Morely experiment

4) How is the Michelson-Morely experiment related to Albert Einstein's theory of relativity?

a) In 1887, Albert Michelson and Edward Morely carried out experiments to detect the change in speed of light due to ether wind when the Earth moved around the sun. The result was negative. They found the speed of light is always the same regardless of Earth's motion around the sun. Scientists were puzzled with this negative result, and they didn't know how to explain it. Albert Einstein came up with the answer in his famous second postulate in theory of relativity: that the speed of light (in vacuum) is always constant and absolute, regardless of its source's motion and observer's movement.

Please note that if you are then going to export the Respondus file into a Brookes VLE assessment you will still have to mark the question yourself.

Importing Short Answer Questions

To import a Short Answer question, the first line of formatting must begin with Type: S. This is followed by the Title (which is optional), the question number, and the question wording.

Example: Type: S

Title: Who invented television?

5. Who is known as the father of television?

Respondus allows you to import only one correct answer per question, but it does permit you to enter multiple forms of that answer.

Example: Type: S

Title: Who invented television?

5. Who is known as the father of television?

- a. Zworykin
- b. Vladimir Zworykin
- c. Vladimir Kosma Zworykin

Importing Matching Questions

The process of importing a matching question is similar to what is described above for importing multiple choice questions, but there are some key differences. The first line of formatting must begin with Type: MT. This is followed by the title (which is optional), the question number, and the question wording.

Each answer (which consists of both portions of a correct match) must begin with a letter (a-z) followed by a full stop or parentheses. The two parts of the match must be separated with an = symbol and there should not be any hard returns or blank lines within either parts of the answer.

Example: Type: MT

Title: Scientific discoveries

4) Match the correct name to the discovery or theory.

- a. Michelson-Morely = Speed of light
- b. Einstein = Theory of Relativity
- c. Marconi = radio waves

Spaces before or after the = symbol are optional, but it is important that an answer only uses the = symbol for the purpose of separating the two parts of the match.

Importing Multiple Response Questions

The logic for importing multiple response questions is similar to what is described above for importing multiple choice questions. (Multiple Response questions are, essentially, multiple choice questions in which more than one correct answer can be selected by the student). The main difference is that the first line of the formatting must begin with Type: MR. This is followed by the Title (which is optional), the question number, and the question wording. Correct answers are designated with an asterisk.

Example: Type: MR

3) Which of the following individuals are credited with determining the exact speed of light?

- a. Albert Einstein
- *b. Albert Michelson
- c. Thomas Edison
- *d. Edward Williams Morley

To include a title or feedback with multiple response questions, follow the same formatting rules described above for multiple choice questions.

Important: Once the import file is organized to the specifications described above, it should be saved as a rich-text (.rtf), text (.txt), or Microsoft Word (.doc) file.

Question Starts

A routine for creating thought-provoking questions.

1. Brainstorm a list of at least 12 questions about the topic, concept or object. Use these question-starts to help you think of interesting questions:

Why...?

What are the reasons...?

What if...?

What is the purpose of...?

How would it be different if...?

Suppose that...?

What if we knew...?

What would change if...?

2. Review the brainstormed list and star the questions that seem most interesting. Then, select one or more of the starred questions to discuss for a few moments.
3. Reflect: What new ideas do you have about the topic, concept or object that you didn't have before?

Purpose: What kind of thinking does this routine encourage?

This routine provides students with the opportunity to practice developing good questions that provoke thinking and inquiry into a topic. It also helps students brainstorm lots of different kinds of questions about a topic. The purpose of asking deep and interesting questions is to get at the complexity and depth of a topic. The purpose of brainstorming varied questions about a topic is to get at the breadth and multi-dimensionality of a topic.

Application: When and where can I use it?

Use Question Starts to expand and deepen students' thinking, to encourage students' curiosity, and to increase their motivation to inquire. This routine can be used when you are introducing a new topic to help students get a sense of the breadth of a topic. It can be used when you're in the middle of studying a topic as a way of enlivening students' curiosity. And it can be used when you are near the end of studying a topic, as a way of showing students how the knowledge they have gained about the topic helps them to ask ever more interesting questions. This routine can also be used continuously throughout a topic, to help the class keep a visible, evolving list of questions about the topic that can be added to at anytime.

Launch: What are some tips for starting and using this routine?

Before using Question Starts, you might want to ask students what they think makes a good question. Then, when you show the Question Starts, explain that this routine is a tool for asking good questions. Start the routine by providing a topic– Stockholm, a compass, the Equator, good sportsmanship. Ask them to use the Question Starts to generate a list of questions about the topic. Initially, it's best to work together as an entire group. Once students get the hang of the routine, you can have them work in small groups or even solo. Or mix it up. For example, do step 1 as a whole class, do step 2 in pairs, and step 3 as a whole class again.

After students finish generating questions, you can use the questions they created in a variety of ways: pick one of the questions to investigate further, have a discussion about some of the questions, give students information to read about the topic, ask them to investigate it in other ways, or do nothing further as simply creating the list of questions is worthwhile since it gives students a sense of the breadth of a topic and sparks curiosity about it. Students' questions can be written down and recorded so that they are listed for all to see. If students are working solo, they can keep their list of questions in a journal, or you can create a "collage" out of students' individual lists and display it on the classroom wall.

Share your experience with this thinking routine on social media using the hashtags [#PZThinkingRoutines](#) and [#QuestionStarts](#).



This thinking routine was developed as part of the Visible Thinking project at Project Zero, Harvard Graduate School of Education.

Explore more Thinking Routines at pz.harvard.edu/thinking-routines